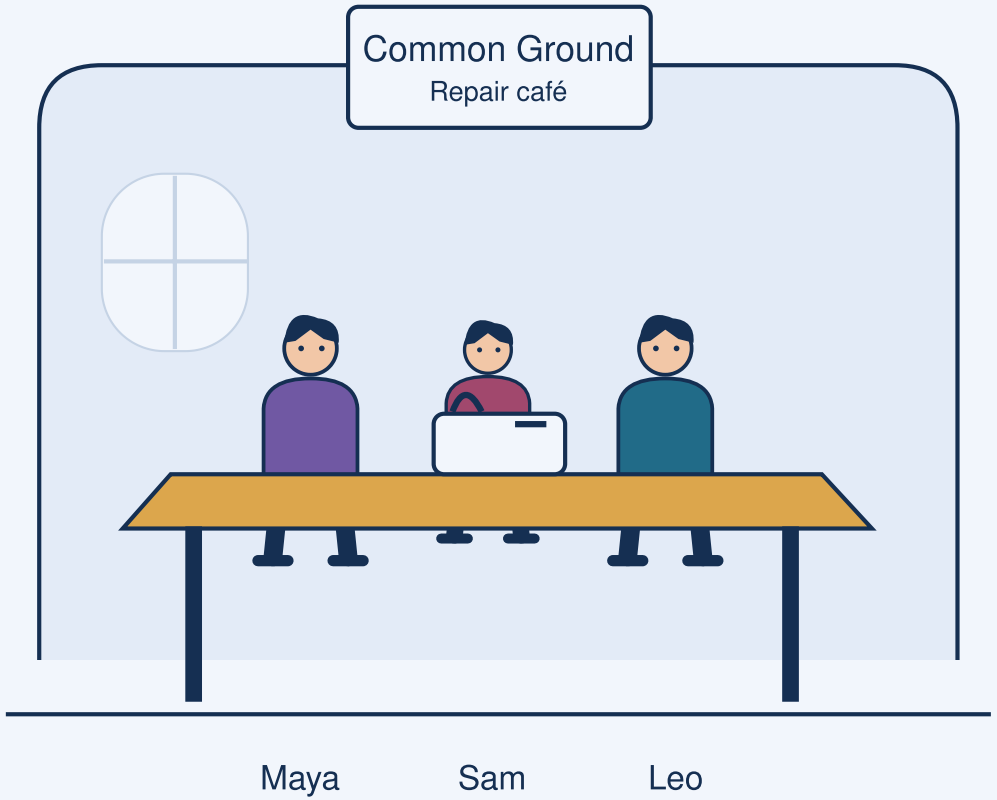
Two teams stop sharing a table.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

The shared checklist is unfinished. What is a useful first change?

A Agree on owners, deadlines, and needed support.

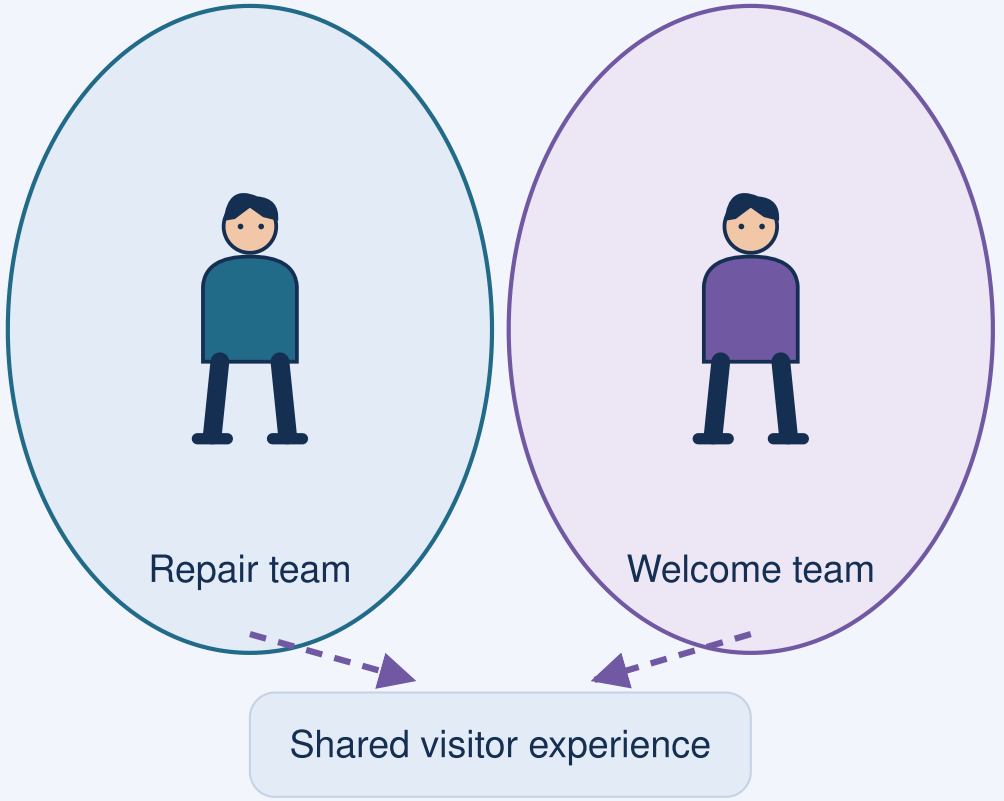
B Tell everyone their commitment is disappointing.

C Copy more people onto every task.

Suggested answer: A. This directly addresses responsibility and coordination.

Identity changes the boundary of “us.”

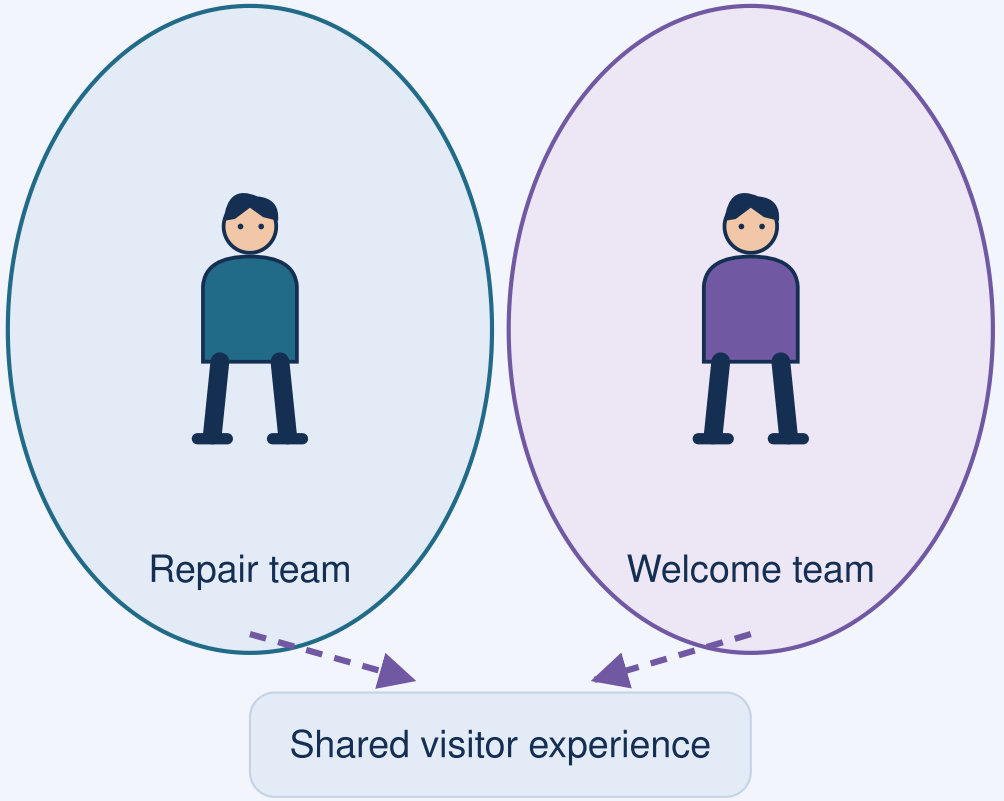
- Social identity: belonging shapes the self.
- In-group favoritism: favoring “our” side.
- Shared goals can widen the circle.



Separate teams can coordinate around a shared goal.

Groups can amplify—or lose—effort.

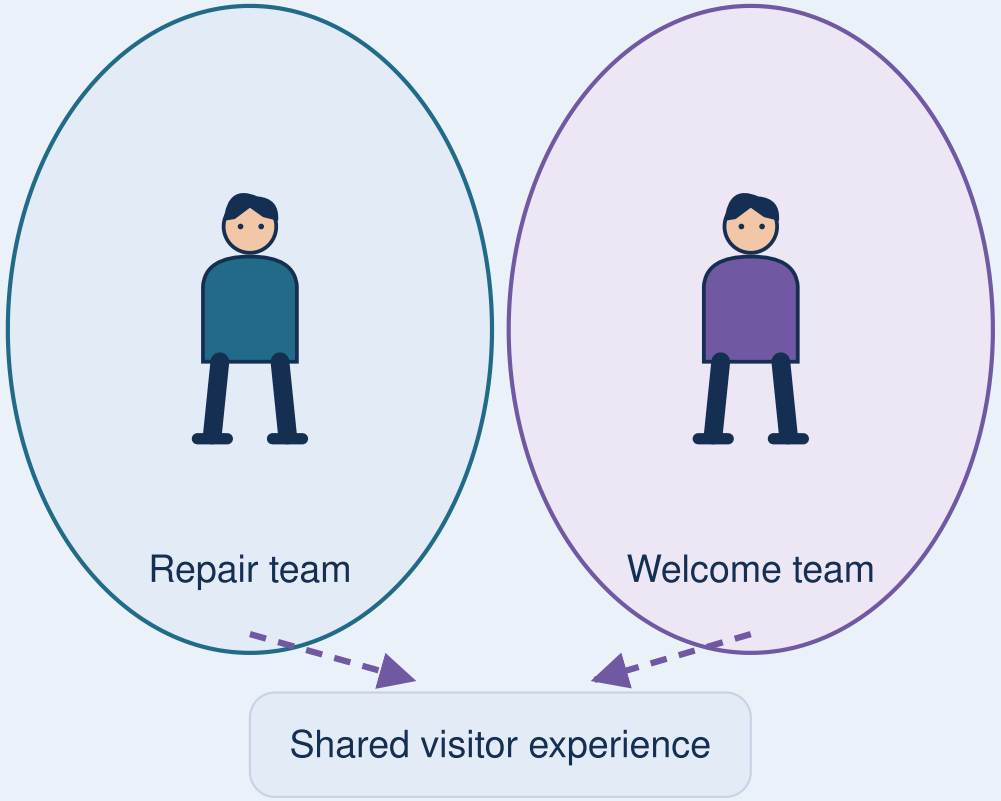
- Polarization: discussion can intensify an initial leaning.
- Social loafing: individual effort can fall in pooled work.
- Coordination loss: real effort is poorly combined.



Separate teams can coordinate around a shared goal.

What can we really conclude?

Groupthink is a label for some failures of critical discussion, not a complete explanation whenever a group makes a mistake. Seek observable processes: suppressed dissent, repeated information, incentives, effort, or coordination. Independent estimates, clear roles, and structured disagreement solve different problems. Avoid calling a group irrational without identifying what would improve its decisions.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

An event budget keeps escalating without checking demand. What helps?

A Ask members to show stronger enthusiasm.

B Gather independent estimates and contrary evidence.

C Open with the chair’s preferred budget.

Suggested answer: B. This introduces information beyond the existing enthusiasm.

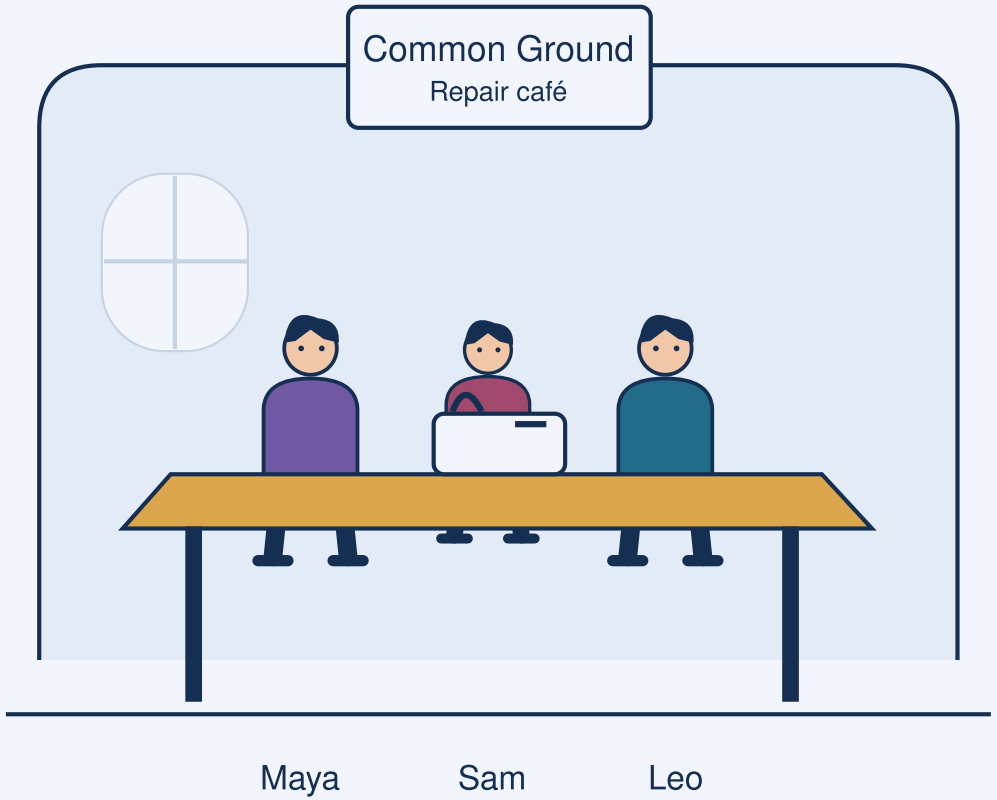
Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does polarization differ from consensus?

> How can a willing group still perform poorly?

1. Consensus is agreement; polarization moves toward a more extreme position from an initial leaning.

2. Poor sequencing, duplication, missing tools, or ambiguous roles can waste genuine effort.

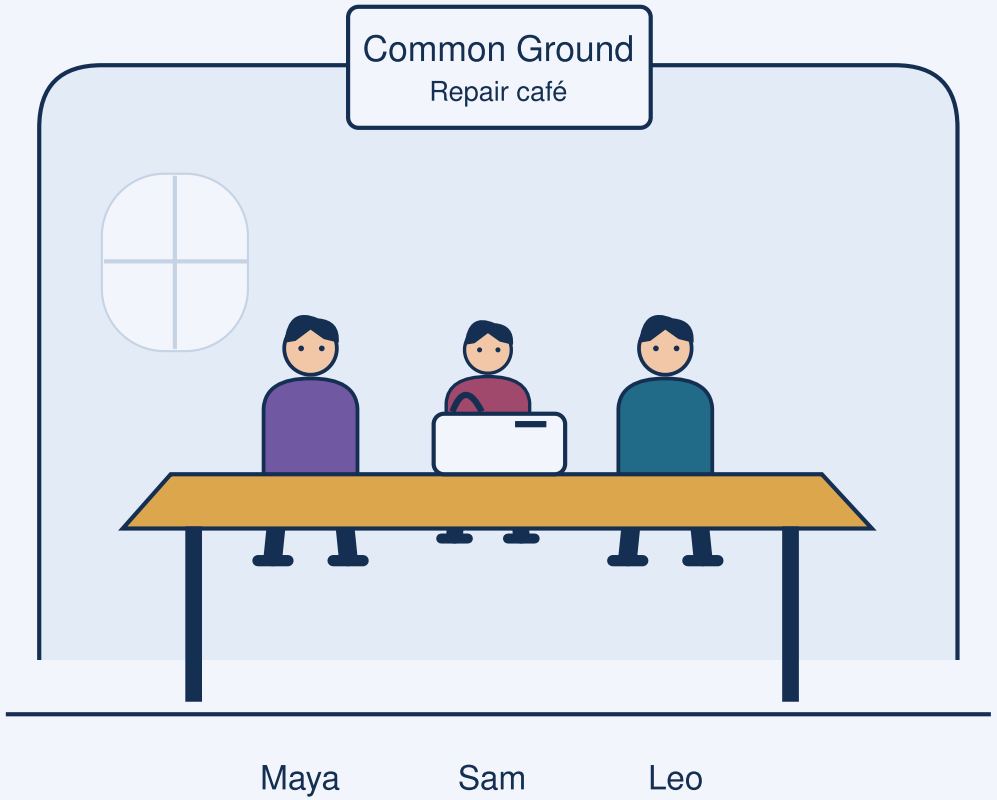


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Map a shared project: task, owner, dependency, and feedback point. Decide whether its main obstacle is effort, coordination, or decision quality before proposing a remedy.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.